

WHAT

ABOUT OBJECTS?

You can't walk through an object, can you? Try it with a tree so that you can be sure it has physical reality and is not a phantom tree. However, we know that some things exist, despite the fact that we cannot see or touch them. For example, we deduce that magnetism and electricity exist because we are able to perceive their physical effects on other things. They are real because we recognize their impact.

HOW

ABOUT COLORS?

Color is a visual property of light. It is true that people perceive colors differently—a flower that seems pink to one person may seem orange to someone else. Yet our interpretation of shades of color does not detract from their existence. Similarly, people who are colorblind may confuse certain colors, but that is because they are unable to detect color as most of us do. It does not mean that colors are not real.

COULD

NUMBERS BE DESCRIBED AS REAL?

Some people would say that numbers (numerals) are made-up concepts, and clearly it is true that we cannot see or eat numbers. But if they are just ideas in our minds, how come we can all agree what the number six is, for example? According to Plato (c. 427–347 BCE) and other Greek philosophers, numbers exist in a realm beyond space and time. That's a difficult concept to calculate.

SURELY

VIRTUAL REALITY IS REAL?

No. Virtual reality (VR) is a name given to computer-simulated environments that you experience through the senses—usually sight and sound but sometimes touch, too. They only imitate reality. The goal of the producers of VR software is to make their stuff so convincing that you are ready to believe that it is real.



"REALITY IS THAT WHICH, WHEN YOU STOP BELIEVING IN IT, DOESN'T GO AWAY."

Philip K. Dick (1928–1982),
science-fiction author